Annual Report 2023 - Northwind Research Group

Northwind Research Group works across medical research, software, finance and security. This report summarizes the year for each division. All figures are fictional and exist only for the RAG lessons.

Section 1: Medical Research

The medical research division completed the second phase of its trial for XR-472, an experimental treatment for chronic migraine. Of the 340 patients enrolled, 61% reported at least a 50% drop in monthly migraine days after twelve weeks. Side effects were mild and mostly limited to drowsiness during the first week. The division plans to start the third phase in the spring, pending approval from the review board. A partnership with two university hospitals will double the number of trial sites.

Section 2: Software Engineering

The software team rebuilt the patient data platform on a new event-driven architecture. Average page load time fell from 2.8 seconds to 0.9 seconds, and the platform handled a peak of 12,000 requests per minute without errors. The team moved all services to automated deployment, which cut the release cycle from two weeks to two days. Test coverage rose to 84%. Next year the team will focus on offline support for clinicians working in rural areas.

Section 3: Financial Analysis

Revenue grew 18% to 412 million dollars, driven by licensing income from the software platform. Operating costs rose 9%, mainly because of new hires in research. The gross margin improved from 54% to 58%. The group spent 96 million dollars on research and development, the largest amount in its history. Cash reserves stand at 150 million dollars, enough to fund the third trial phase without new borrowing.

Section 4: Cybersecurity

In the fourth quarter, the security team detected and contained incident INC-2023-Q4-011, an attempt to access the patient data platform with stolen employee credentials. The attackers reached a test environment but no production data. The team reset all affected accounts within four hours and made hardware security keys mandatory for every employee. An external audit in December found no remaining vulnerabilities related to the incident.

Section 5: Outlook

For 2024 the group expects revenue growth between 12% and 15%. The main priorities are the third phase of the XR-472 trial, offline support in the patient data platform, and a security training program for all staff. The board approved a budget increase of 10% for research and development.